enters the world containing 77 files spread across 45 directories. That's before you've written a thing.

You need an environment that helps you navigate quickly among these. You'll add a line to a controller to load a value, switch to the view to add a line to display it, and then switch to the test to verify you did it all right. Something like Notepad, where you traverse a File Open dialog box to select each file to edit, won't cut it. We prefer a combination of a tree view of files in a sidebar, a small set of keystrokes that help us find a file (or files) in a directory tree by name, and some built-in smarts that know how to navigate (say) between a controller action and the corresponding view.

- Name completion. Names in Rails tend to be long. A nice editor will let you type the first few characters and then suggest possible completions to you at the touch of a key.

Where's My IDE?

If you're coming to Ruby and Rails from languages such as C# and Java, you may be wondering about IDEs. After all, we all know that it's impossible to code modern applications without at least 100 MB of IDE supporting our every keystroke. For you enlightened ones, here's the point in the book where we recommend you sit down—ideally propped up on each side by a pile of framework references and 1,000-page Made Easy books.

It may surprise you to know that most Rails developers don't use fully-fledged IDEs for Ruby or Rails (although some of the environments come close). Indeed, many Rails developers use plain old editors. And it turns out that this isn't as much of a problem as you might think. With other, less expressive languages, programmers rely on IDEs to do much of the grunt work for them because IDEs do code generation, assist with navigation, and compile incrementally to give early warning of errors.

With Ruby, however, much of this support isn't necessary. Editors such as Zed, Neovim, and RubyMine give you 90 percent of what you'd get from an IDE but are far lighter weight.